The children grew up in a court composed of an eclectic mix of people —their older, adoring Timurid matriarchs, Rajput mothers and attendants, Shaikh Salim's relatives, Persian noblemen, and Hindu courtiers, musicians, and artisans. They would be raised amidst a polyphony of languages and customs and Shaikhu Baba would grow up to become an elegant writer of Persian who also composed Hindi verses. As Emperor Jahangir he would develop an appreciation for Hindi verses. He was once so moved by a poet who wrote verses praising him, calling him the son of the Sun, that he gave him an elephant in reward. Jahangir would later even offer grudging admiration of Daniyal, who 'was fond of Hindi songs and would occasionally compose verses with correct idiom in the language of the people of India, which were not bad'.

Akbar's care did not stop with just his sons and daughters. '[Akbar] maintains, and gives a liberal education to many noble boys and youths who have lost their fathers'. Whenever Akbar spied a glimmer of talent or goodness in any deserving waif, like Daswant the artist, he would take them in and put personal effort into forming them. Jahangir would later write of one 'Lal Kalawant, who from his childhood had grown up in my father's service, who had taught him every breathing and sound that appertains to the Hindi language'. There was also Manohar, of the clan of the Shekhawat Kachhwahas, on whom, 'in his young days my father had bestowed many favours. He had learned the Persian language and, although from him up to Adam the power of understanding cannot be attributed to any one of his tribe', was Jahangir's brisk assessment, 'he is not without intelligence'. However, of all the princes and youth at Fatehpur it was Shaikhu Baba who would be, for a while at least, the adored and chosen heir. His would be the grandest celebrations and the greatest honours, and he would be repeatedly sent to greet or accompany journeying royal women. And the harem, in turn, would always be united in their efforts to bolster the sometimes faltering trajectory of this complicated prince. For the candescent gaze of Padshah Akbar was not always easy to bear, especially as the princes grew older. 'He used to give them orders rather roughly whenever he wanted anything done,' wrote the Jesuit priests about Akbar and his sons, 'and he sometimes punished them with blows as well as with harsh words.' This made Murad 'so submissive that he sometimes did not even dare to raise his eyes to his teacher's face when he was reproving him'. It may not be altogether surprising that Jahangir noted that his father's 'august voice was